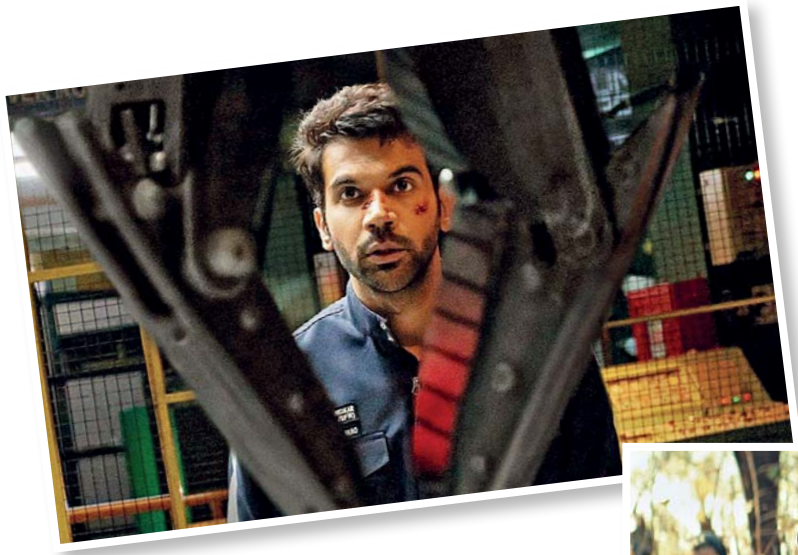




CLASS ACTS Rajkummar Rao in stills from (left) Monica, O My Darling and Newton (2017)

Not everybody will like Jayant, the character Rajkummar Rao plays in the Netflix film *Monica, O My Darling* (releasing on November 11). Neither is he the idealistic Shahid or Newton whom audiences rooted for, nor is he the lovable fool of *Bareilly Ki Barfi* (2017) and *Stree* (2018), someone who charmed our hearts. Jayant is, in Rao's words, an "opportunist" and a "victim of circumstances". Life pushes him onto an immoral path, one laden with dead bodies, diabolical characters, and, strangely, snakes and robots. It is to Rao's credit that he brings out the "humanness" in Jayant. There are points when he also manages to make audiences feel a touch sorry for him. "I never saw him as a villain," says Rao. "He is an aspiring, small-town guy who wants to have a good life. But one wrong step and he is in trouble. When you are stuck, you do everything possible to come out of it. The whole film is about survival."

Rao himself is well-versed in the art of survival. He first made his mark as a manipulative supermarket supervisor in *LSD: Love, Sex Aur Dhokha* (2010), and 10 years ago, he won a National Award for his performance in *Shahid* (2012), a biopic about the lawyer and human rights activist Shahid Azmi. It has also only been five years since he entered the Rs 100 crore club with the horror comedy *Stree*. Using his acting ability, Rao hasn't just survived in a competitive industry, he has flourished. Having started with mainly independent features, his filmography is fast coming to include studio-driven films as well.

It should perhaps also come as no surprise that Rao, an actor known for his pluck and versatility, is one of very few stars who choose to shuttle between work for OTT platforms and the big screen. *Monica, O My Darling* is his third Netflix release after *The White Tiger* (2021) and *Ludo* (2020). After *Monica, O My Darling*, his next will be Raj & DK's *Guns & Gulaabs*. Set in the 1990s, the show's cast includes Dulquer, Adarsh Gourav and Gulshan Devaiah. "The world has changed. We want our films to be watched. It doesn't matter whether it is on a big or small screen," he says while citing the success of shows like *Money Heist* (2017-2021) and *Squid Game* (2021—). "Streaming is a strong parallel industry that will now be there." In a sense, though, Rao has always been ahead of the curve. Back in 2017, he had even shaved a part of his head for the AltBalaji series *Bose: Dead/Alive* (2017). Many of his peers soon began to follow Rao's lead. Not only did OTT platforms give them an opportunity to transcend linguistic and geographic boundaries, but they also gave them a chance to find new audiences. Rao does, however, bemoan the fact that after the Covid-19 pandemic, a more rigid demarcation has begun to emerge. "You hear people say, 'This is an OTT film!' A film is a film. They will exist on both platforms. I hope people stop putting films in brackets," he says.

Monica, O My Darling showcases a side of Rao that is both familiar and fantastic: the ordinary, occasionally awkward man, faced with extraordinary circumstances. Many of Rao's films—*Trapped*

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